

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a local magazine:

Can you understand Hong Kong if you don't speak Cantonese?

People who live and work in Hong Kong often struggle if they cannot speak Cantonese. It can be simple everyday problems like speaking to a taxi driver or getting served in a restaurant. As a result, recently more and more people are studying Cantonese. Total enrollment for Cantonese programmes grew by about 30% from 1,508 in 2010 to 1,918 last year at the Chinese University of Hong Kong. Other institutions also report this trend.

Typical of the increasing number of people studying Cantonese is Jonathan Ma, a 33-year-old English teacher, who was born in Hong Kong but moved to the United Kingdom when he was a child so he never learnt Cantonese. Ma recently began learning Cantonese intensively and he now realises how important it is not just for day-to-day living but also for understanding Hong Kong culture.

While Hong Kong is a city where many people speak English or Putonghua, Cantonese dominates the local language scene and those who are not proficient in Cantonese can feel isolated from local culture, and find it difficult to establish relationships with the many locals who cannot speak the language that they do.

Not having Cantonese limits not only their social circle but also their ability to understand issues that are important to Hongkongers and to integrate themselves into local communities.

You are doing a project on the importance of Cantonese in everyday life in Hong Kong. You may want to talk about:

- problems non-Cantonese speaking people may have if they live in Hong Kong
- advantages if they learn Cantonese
- ways to help people who do not speak Cantonese feel more connected to Hong Kong
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you think it is easy to learn Chinese?
2. Do you know someone who can't speak Cantonese?
3. What can you do to help someone learn Cantonese?
4. Can you tell me a job where speaking Cantonese is a must?
5. Do you think it is more important to read or to speak Chinese?
6. Are adults too old to learn how to speak Cantonese?
7. Do you think Cantonese will become less important in the future?
8. Should more be done to promote the use of Cantonese to non-Cantonese speakers?